



12th

Chasing dreams: With the World Cup expanded to 32 teams, unfancied Croatia upstaged the heavyweights to finish third in the 1998 edition. Forward Davor Suker, who won the Golden Boot with six goals, celebrates his side's quarterfinal victory over Germany. AFP

1998

FRANCE



13th

Standing tall: French midfielder Zinedine Zidane (10) rises highest to head home his side's opening goal in the 3-0 win over Brazil in the World Cup final in Paris. France, captained by Didier Deschamps, won its maiden title. AP

HYPER-MODERN ERA

The post-millennium World Cup years will be remembered for football becoming increasingly tactical-focused, data-infused and, more recently, technology-driven. While Johan Cruyff and the Dutch introduced 'Total Football' to the world in the 1970s, his disciple Pep Guardiola modernised the philosophy through Barcelona's tiki-taka, which went on to shape Spain's dominance and heavily influence the game over the last two decades. The emergence of Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo also gave birth to a modern sporting rivalry that transcended the playing surface.

2002

SOUTH KOREA AND JAPAN



14th

Asian revolution: The World Cup was staged outside Europe and the Americas for the first time. South Korea made home advantage count by reaching the semifinals. In this picture, South Korea's Ahn Jung Hwan (19) scores the winner against Italy in their Round of 16 clash. AP



15th

Ronaldo redeemed: Redemption arrived for Brazil's Ronaldo. After intense scrutiny over his subdued display in the 1998 final, the striker made amends by scoring twice in the final against Germany in Yokohama as Brazil claimed its fifth World Cup title. AP